



2026 Betclic Elite (LNB) predictions based on Statistical Analytics Models

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This article was edited and co-authored by Ioannis Ntzoufras, Professor of Statistics at AUEB, Argyro Damoulaki, PhD Candidate in the same department and Antoine Rustenholz, who is doing an internship in the same department and comes from the University École Nationale de la Statistique et de l'Analyse de l'Information in Rennes (France).

The Betclic Elite Finals have now come to an end with the consecration of AS Monaco after five intense and tight games. In a very unexpected scenario, Paris Basketball failed to convert its home-court advantage into an overall victory, while AS Monaco defied predictions to claim their third French Championship title.

The following report looks back on the predictions made before and after every game, with the aim of assessing how well or poorly the model performed throughout the Finals.

Reminder for friends of Statistics

The predictions in this report are based on a simple statistical approach (Vanilla Model), which relies exclusively on regular season results to estimate team performance. The model uses neither external information, such as betting odds or standings, nor any factor beyond team identity and historical results — including those from the previous season, given that rosters did not change radically, especially among the finalists. Win probabilities are derived through statistical modelling and repeated match simulations. While no model can predict the outcome of a match with certainty, this approach provides an objective and data-driven assessment of each team's chances.

Model comparisons

The model was trained over three different datasets:

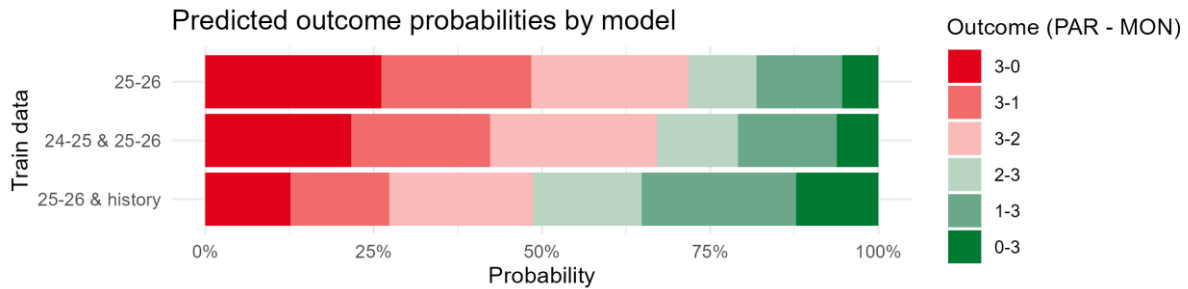
- The 2025-26 season only
- Both the 2024-25 and 2025-26 seasons
- The 2025-26 season supplemented with the head-to-head history between AS Monaco and Paris Basketball over the past two Finals

The following table and figure present the probabilities of the outcomes depending on the dataset used to train the model.

Table 1: Overall probabilities of winning for both teams depending on the train dataset

Train dataset	Probability of overall victory (%)	
	Paris Basketball	AS Monaco
2025-26	71.8	28.2
2024-25 & 2025-26	67.1	32.9
2025-26 & head-to-head	48.7	51.3

Figure 1: Predicted probabilities for all the possible outcomes



All three models predicted Paris Basketball as the favourite, except for the third model, which produced a near-even split. Even though Paris Basketball is favoured in most cases, the most likely outcome overall is a 3-2 victory for Paris, suggesting the Finals were expected to remain close regardless of how strongly Paris was favoured.

The model retained for the following analysis is the second one, trained on both the current and previous seasons, as it relies on the largest and most homogeneous dataset. The first model was considered less robust due to its reliance on a single season. Same for the third model, even though it was conceptually appealing because it directly incorporates the head-to-head history between the two finalists.

The prediction of the retained model is moreover consistent with the observed home-court advantage in the playoffs. As a matter of fact, over the past five seasons, 61.5% of playoff games were won by the home team, which granted Paris Basketball a structural edge as regular season leader. Furthermore, no team had won the Finals without home-court advantage since 2013, making AS Monaco's victory even more remarkable.

However, it is worth noting that the third model was the only one to predict AS Monaco as the slight favourite, which happened to be the correct call at the end of the day.

Initial predictions

The following table presents the probabilities of the outcome of each of the potential five games of the Finals based on the model trained on the 2024-25 and 2025-26 seasons dataset. As said before, this model strongly favours the home team, and in this case the home team is predicted to win each of the five games. However, Paris Basketball is predicted to win by a larger margin when playing at home than AS Monaco is.

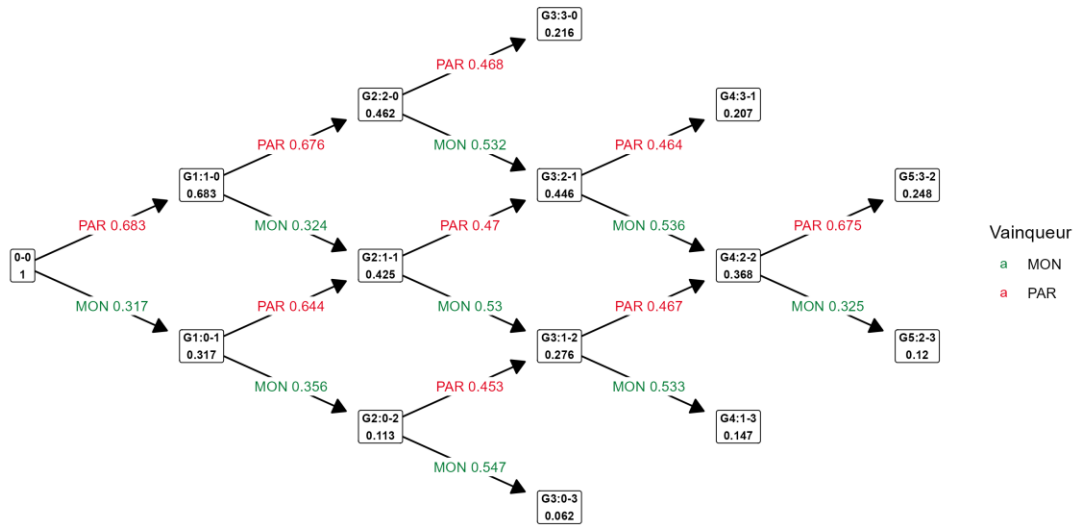
Table 2: Game per game probabilities before first game

Game	Home team	Predicted probability (%)		Most likely score difference (probability (%))	Probability of played game (%)
		Victory home	Victory away		
1	Paris Basketball	68.3	31.7	+6 (3.1)	100
2	Paris Basketball	66.6	33.4	+6 (2.9)	100
3	AS Monaco	53.3	46.7	+1 (2.9)	100
4	AS Monaco	53.5	46.5	+1 (2.8)	72.2
5	Paris Basketball	67.5	32.5	+6 (3.6)	36.8

The following figure presents the detailed probabilities for each game and the different possible paths all over the Finals. At the end of the day, the most likely scenario is indeed a 3-2 for Paris Basketball with 24.8%.

Figure 2: Probability tree of the possible outcomes before the first game

Probability tree of the possible outcomes



Stage of the series: before the first game
Model: trained on seasons 25 and 26

Evolution of the predictions through the games

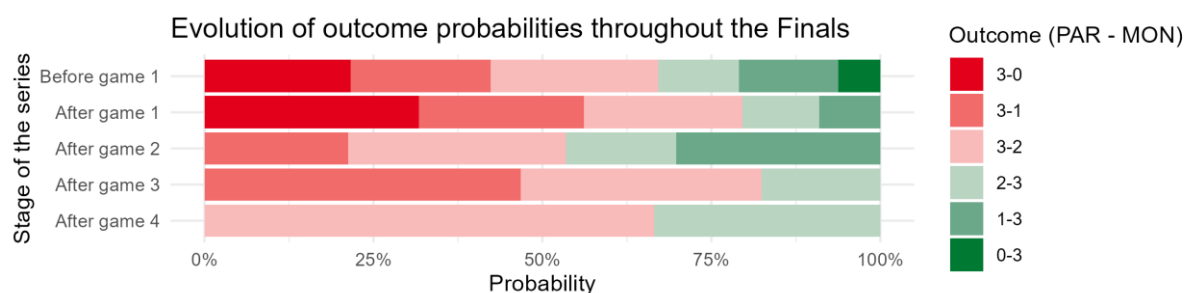
A closer look at how predictions evolved game after game reveals that they barely changed throughout the series. The largest shift between the initial probability and the latest update never exceeds 1.5 percentage points. This holds true even after unexpected results: AS Monaco's 12-point win in game 2 only moved their own win probability for game 3 (as the home team) by 1.4 percentage points, from 53.3% to 54.7%, and Paris Basketball's 11-point win in game 3 barely affected AS Monaco's win probability for game 4, which dropped from 53.5% to 53.2%.

Table 3: Probabilities and outcomes of the games updated after each game
Legend: initial predicted probability / before the current game predicted probability

Game	Home team	Predicted probability (%)		True outcome	Most likely score difference (probability (%))
		Victory home	Victory away		
1	Paris Basketball	68.3 / 68.3	31.7 / 31.7	+4	+6 (3.1)
2	Paris Basketball	66.6 / 68.0	33.4 / 32.0	-12	+6 (2.9)
3	AS Monaco	53.3 / 54.7	46.7 / 45.3	-11	+1 (2.9)
4	AS Monaco	53.5 / 53.2	46.5 / 46.8	+12	+1 (2.8)
5	Paris Basketball	67.5 / 66.5	32.5 / 33.5	-9	+6 (3.6)

The following figure presents how the distribution of likely outcomes shifted after each game. Unlike the relatively stable game-level predictions discussed previously, the series-level outcome distribution reacts more to results, since each game necessarily eliminates outcomes that are no longer possible. After Paris Basketball's game 1 win, the 3-0 and 3-1 scenarios (in favour of Paris) become more prominent, while after AS Monaco's win in game 2, the distribution shifts sharply towards Monaco-favoured outcomes (2-3, 1-3). From the second match onwards, the number of possible outcomes decreases. Paris Basketball's 3-2 victory, which was already the initial most likely outcome, becomes increasingly probable as the series advances. Finally, as Paris Basketball were playing the fifth match at home, the model predicted they would win that final match and, consequently, the title. However, AS Monaco managed to win on Paris Basketball's home-court again.

Figure 3: Evolution of probabilities of the possible outcomes throughout the Finals



Rethinking the model selection

After all, the choice to set aside the third model, the one that included the head-to-head history between AS Monaco and Paris Basketball, deserves a second look. Initially, this model was discarded mainly because it predicted an overall victory for the away team, which is something that goes against the data of the past 15 seasons. Furthermore, its estimate relied on a smaller number of matches, making it statistically less robust than the model ultimately chosen.

However, this case is a useful reminder that statistical robustness and predictive accuracy do not always match, especially in a single event such as a Finals series between two specific opponents. The head-to-head model captured something the others could not: a direct signal of how these two teams perform against each other specifically, beyond their performance against the rest of the league.

It is impossible to determine, based on a single Finals series, whether this is a coincidence or a genuinely meaningful indicator. This approach would need to be tested over several seasons and across many matches before any definitive conclusions can be drawn one way or the other.

Model limitations

Beyond this specific judgment call, the model itself relies on a small set of assumptions. It estimates team strength only from score differentials and home advantage, without accounting for many factors such as player form, team cohesion, schedule congestion, or the psychological dynamics specific to high-stakes games. For instance, a team facing elimination may play differently than the same team in a regular season game. More precise data, such as player-level availability or game-level context, could probably improve the model. Furthermore, the Vanilla Model may be too elementary in this case. Using more advanced approaches, for instance bivariate score models, multinomial models or Bradley-Terry model could also improve predictions.

The Magic Equations of the Statistical Model

$$Y_g = \mu + \alpha_{h(g)} - \alpha_{a(g)} + \varepsilon_g \quad , \quad \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$$

subject to the identification constraint

$$\alpha_{\text{PAR}} = 0$$

where:

- Y_g denotes the score difference in game g , calculated as the home team's score minus the away team's score.
- μ is the global home advantage, common to all teams.
- $h(g)$ denotes the team playing at home in game g .
- $a(g)$ denotes the team playing away in game g .
- α_i is the single ability coefficient associated with team i , shared across home and away appearances.
- The constraint $\alpha_{\text{PAR}} = 0$ ensures identifiability by setting Paris Basketball as the reference team.
- ε_g is the random error term, assumed to follow a normal distribution with mean zero and variance σ^2 .

The expected score difference for a game between home team $h(g)$ and away team $a(g)$ is

$$\mathbb{E}(Y_g) = \mu + \alpha_{h(g)} - \alpha_{a(g)}$$

The AUEB Sports Analytics Team



The research team of the Athens University of Economics and Business AUEB Sports Analytics Group was founded in 2015 by Professors Ioannis Ntzoufras and Dimitris Karlis. Its members are important members of the sports analytics community such as Leonardo Egidi (University of Trieste), Ioannis Kosmidis (Warwick), Konstantinos Pelehrinis (Pittsburgh), Nial Friel (UCD) and Gianluca Baio (UCL) as well as the former coach of the Greek National Volleyball Team, Sotiris Drikos and the scouter of the Sacramento Kings, Christos Marmarinos. The research team is responsible for the

series of annual conferences called AUEB Sports Analytics Workshop (6 in total) and in 2019 organized the international conference MathSport 2019 with 200 participating scientists from all over the world. The team has a number of important scientific publications in the field of sports analytics. Finally, we would like to mention that the team was founded in 2015 due to the visit of Professor Stefan Kesenne (University of Antwerp & Leuven), a great Sports Economist who also played an active role in the Bosman case. Stefan Kesenne actively supported the team until 2021 when he suddenly passed away. The existence of the AUEB Sports Analytics Group is largely due to the contribution and inspiration given to us by Mr. Kesenne.

Group website: <https://aueb-analytics.wixsite.com/sports>

Listen to the podcast on Basketball Analytics by Ioannis Ntzoufras, Argyro Damoulaki and Christos Marmarinos [here](#).

A few words about the Authors



Ioannis Ntzoufras is Professor of Statistics and Chairman of the Department of Statistics of the Athens University of Economics and Business. He is a founding member of AUEB Sports Analytics Group along with Dimitris Karlis. He has recognized scientific activity in areas such as Bayesian statistical methodology, computational statistics, biostatistics, psychometrics and sports analytics.



Argyro Damoulaki is a PhD candidate at the Department of Statistics of AUEB. Her current research focuses on performance evaluation models using Bayesian statistics. She is involved in sports analytics and has been an active member of AUEB Sports Analytics Group since 2022.



Antoine Rustenholz is a fourth-year student (Engineering Degree) in Statistics at the École Nationale de la Statistique et de l'Analyse de l'Information, University of Rennes, France. He is completing his internship as a sports data analyst at the Computational and Bayesian Statistics Lab of the Department of Statistics and at the AUEB Sports Analytics Group.